of physical reality existing apart from minds. Since the awareness of blue is simultaneous with the blue thing, and blue and the awareness of blue never occur separately, we must assume that they are the same. As interpreted by in the Buddhist idealist ***Vijnanavada***, this means that that there is nothing external to minds. As interpreted by ***Sautrantikas*** like ***Dharmakirti***, it means that we only know our ideas and that we cannot know reality as it is in itself outside the mind.

Sakara-vada: this is a Buddhist view that each object-awareness has its own form or mental image (*akara*) that distinguishes it from other ideas. The form is what we are directly aware of and think with. It may derive from some extra-mental reality of which we have received sensory impressions, or it may just be an idea. The former is the view of the ***Sautrantikas*** and the latter that of the idealist ***Vijnanavadins*** who hold that everyday unenlightened experience is just consciousness projecting its forms in such a way that they appear to be external objects. From the presence of forms in awareness, ***Sautrantikas*** infer an objective domain that causes them. But since we only know our ideas, we can never be acquainted with whatever causes them.

All Buddhist idealists agreed that the awareness of the enlightened person is free from the distinction between object and cognising subject. But some thought that it is also free from images that are necessarily features of unenlightened experience. They call this ***Nirakara-vada***, an expression that usually labels the view that consciousness is a formless light illuminating a ready-made world of objects.

See ***Dharmakirti***

Further reading: Kajiyama 1998; Matilal 1986